

Acer Aspire 6920

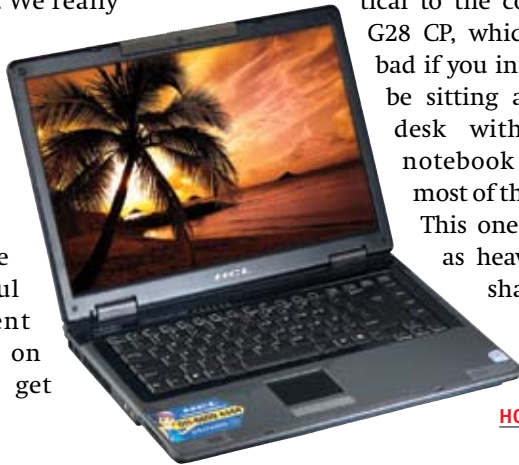
The smaller brother to the Aspire 8920G (by 2.4 screen inches, to be exact) looks identical to its larger, faster and costlier sibling. The quirky touch-type multimedia keys remain unchanged from its older brother. However, it's a lot more portable, although these aren't the type of notebooks anyone would want to cart around. It's as well built as its sibling but makes do without any without any discrete graphics powering its video subsystem. Once again 3 GB of system memory makes the 6920 snappy. Both Acers have a CPU in common.



Acer Aspire 6920

In our collective opinion such a large, powerful notebook simply requires a graphics card and an X3100 video solution just doesn't cut it for viewing HD content, or any kind of serious multimedia usage. And that's the kind of user who will buy such a laptop—a person who wants a powerful notebook to replace his main desktop solution.

At Rs 49,999, the 6920 is a sturdy, large notebook meant to be plonked on to a desk and for the most part, kept there. We really wish for a discrete graphics solution on this one but if wishes were Acers, this one would be an unavoidable recommendation. As it stands, if you're looking for a powerful desktop replacement notebook and you're on a budget, it doesn't get stingier than this.



WORKHORSES UP TO RS 40,000 Plough Nags

HCL G28 CP

At Rs 22,490, the G28 CP is positioned as an entry level solution, and for this price we wouldn't expect much. However, it's got a solid, robust, (if bulky), feel. Thanks to a total lack of design attention, it also feels very clunky. The good thing about it is that if you're ever going to get caught in an alley by a mugger, then this is the notebook you would probably wish you had.

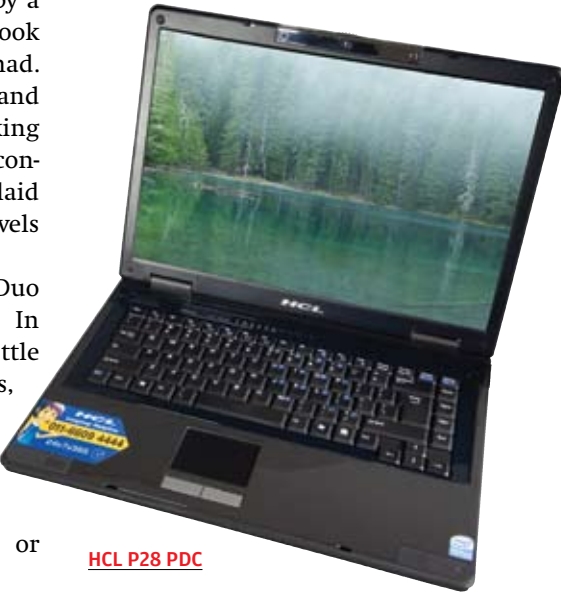
The keypad isn't too bad, and the keys, although lacking any kind of comfort contouring, are rather well laid out, with acceptable levels of feedback.

An entry-level Core 2 Duo does duty here (T2310). In fact, these processors are little more than dual core Celerons, so don't expect much performance from this notebook. The 1 GB of RAM is decent enough for the target audience who will mostly be using this at office or home for very basic tasks.

If you're even remotely interested in multimedia or a fancy notebook, or even a powerful desktop replacement, then you'd do well to steer clear of this. For someone looking for an entry level notebook, however, this one may be worth considering.

HCL P28 PDC

HCL next offering and basically identical to the cosh-like G28 CP, which isn't bad if you intend to be sitting at your desk with your notebook for most of the time. This one is just as heavy, and shares the



HCL P28 PDC

minutes. For Rs 28,990, this notebook will have takers only from the lot who want a notebook and are graduating there from a desktop. Portability freaks, performance users and aficionados will give this a miss.

HCL B30 C2D

Sporting an identical look to both the earlier HCLs in this category, the B30 C2D offers nothing different to the earlier two expect in terms of configuration. This notebook comes with FreeDOS, so do remember that genuine copies of Windows will add to your purchase price. Also no software is bundled, except for an HCL backup-restore suite.

The 2 GB of RAM and Core 2 Duo T5550 do make the B30 C2D a little faster, and this notebook will handle some multimedia content, (remember we said some). The 80 GB HDD is a backward step and considering the

same keys and feedback. We didn't like the very hard-to-press shortcut buttons on the front bezel. Other convenience issues were the lack of any type of buttons for activating and deactivating WLAN connectivity. Incidentally, Bluetooth is lacking (also on the G28 CP).

Powered by a Core 2 Duo T2330, and 2 GB of RAM, along with a 160 GB hard drive, this has a marginally better configuration, though battery life is down at an abysmal 81



HCL B30 C2D

minimal difference in price of 80 and 160 GB notebook HDDs this is a travesty. For Rs 32,990, the B30 C2D is a decent solution for price conscious buyers, though to be honest, if all you need is access to the Internet and basic office use, both the G28 and the P28 from HCL's own stables would do the trick. You save pretty penny too!

HCL Z24 C2D

This is HCL's first good notebook solution that we reviewed. A 14.1-inch laptop is so much better than a 15.4 inch, especially, when you need to heft it around, and when HCL designs their notebooks to be heavy duty.

At Rs 38,490, the Z24 C2D is good value for money. It's reasonably powerful, reasonably compact,



HCL Z24 C2D

and reasonably functional. For the value conscious home user who wants some mobility, this is a good option.

Intex M722S

A 12.1-inch notebook that wasn't as compact as we'd like and therefore finds itself in this category. It's a little thick, and rather heavy for a 12.1 inch notebook, and aimed squarely at value buyers, which is no excuse for such a mediocre build. Also, one needs to take care when opening the notebook and extending the lid too far back, as the hinge is rather flimsy.

It's got a very basic configuration, but if you are looking for something extremely portable for office use and something that can be lugged home



Intex M722S

with minimal fuss or energy consumption, then the Core 2 Duo T2450 (2.0 GHz), with 1 GB of RAM will suffice.

The clincher for Intex is the price—at Rs 30,900, the M722S is one of the cheapest compacts that money can buy, and makes sense for someone looking for frugal mobility.

Acer Aspire 5290

Acer reminisces with the Lego toys of yesteryear with a return to plastic with their Aspire 5290. The finish although cheap looking, and off white in colour, (the worst colour for dirt prone touch pads), does seem to



Acer Aspire 5290

be of good quality, especially, after a week of regular use.

It's the larger twin of the Aspire 2920, and for a 15.4-inch notebook, its heavy too (3 kg). The configuration is a Core 2 Duo T5550 (1.83 GHz) coupled with 2 GB of RAM is good enough for office work and the Internet on Windows Vista. A shame then, that Acer chose to bundle Linux with this notebook, although frankly we were interested to see the difference this made in the pricing. At Rs 39,139 the Aspire 5290 aspires to be something it is not. Do not aspire to own this, you will find better options among the other contenders.

LG XNote R405

LG's value offering, something for the person who wants quality and a good price sans hassles. All XNote's are very well built, and the R405 looks like one of those notebooks that will outlast your desire to hold on to it. The colour combination on the lid is attractive, white flecks on a smooth black background. The inside is finished in matte antiseptic white that looks well...a little too clean. It's a rather thick notebook however, and not at all compact as you'd expect a 14.1-inch notebook to be. The keypad is well laid out with good spacing between keys, and although not bevelled in any way, it has a very responsive feedback. LG has done a decent job of shortcut keys, no complaints with either the WLAN switch or any of the multimedia keys.